

June 2021

Seniors United Now

SUNBURST

The Newsletter for Seniors United Now

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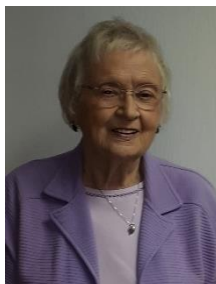
2nd Quarter 2021
Issue 53



The Voice of Seniors in Alberta

SUN PROVINCIAL BOARD APPRECIATION

The Board of Directors regretfully accepted a letter of resignation from Dellah Cohlmin, board secretary. Dellah served in this position for a period of two years. She was a dedicated secretary and a strong member of the board, as an advocate for seniors in Alberta. The board wishes Dellah every success in her future endeavors.



Board Secretary position

The Board of Directors are searching for a replacement secretary and are appealing to our membership for a volunteer. The position is a voting member of the board. If you are interested, please contact the office. We can then arrange an orientation meeting to discuss the details of the position.

Gordon Voth, President

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WEAAD 2021: Rights Don't Get Old



World Elder Abuse Awareness Day (WEAAD), June 15th, annually, serves as a call-to-action for individuals, organizations, and communities to bring attention to the issue of elder abuse, neglect, and exploitation. WEAAD is marked each year on June 15th. It is an official United Nations International Day acknowledging the significance of elder abuse as a public health and human rights issue.

Continued on page4

SUN Pension Committee update

The Board of Directors of SUN, in 2019 received membership feedback regarding the issue of Local Authorities Pension Plan (LAPP) recovery plan for coordinated pensions that are collected for the life of the pensioner. In response to these queries, we conducted a survey of our membership and were surprised by the response that we received. The concern was the fairness of this clause, to seniors who enjoy longevity of life, and the financial impact on them in their old age.

SUN's review of Public Service Pension Act of 1993 does not specify that there is a requirement for recovery for life. We therefore conclude that it is within the jurisdiction of the sponsor Board to change this condition. It is our intention to seek a meeting with the sponsor board, to discuss with them their developing, a policy change, to a fairer and more equitable sunset clause.

The committee decided that we should seek the support of other advocacy groups, to strengthen our request. We attended a meeting with Public Interest Alberta-Senior's task force to seek their support. The task force endorsed our position paper. This group includes 18 senior groups in Alberta. We still need the endorsement of the PIA board.

The outbreak of COVID-19 put a stop to all face-to-face meetings. The pension committee met to discuss whether there is an effective advocacy alternative to meeting with LAPP in person. It was decided that zoom meeting, letters or e-mails would not be effective and so the process was put on hold and will remain on hold until an in-person meeting can be held.

This does not mean that the Board of Directors has given up on recovery for life pension reform. We believe that the recovery clause represents an injustice to seniors and should be amended to include a sunset clause. With vaccinations increasing in Alberta, we hope to readdress this issue soon.

Gordon Voth, President

Questions about seniors programs and services?

**211 now provides enhanced information and referrals
for a variety of seniors resources**



Dial 2-1-1 to be connected to the Seniors Information Phone Line

If you are feeling particularly isolated these days, you are not alone. To help you connect with others, several seniors' organizations are offering friendly calls. To get on a friendly call list, call 211 and press "2" You will be referred to a friendly call program to receive calls from a friendly volunteer on a regular, recurring basis.

211 is a helpline and website that provides information on and referrals to Alberta's community, social, health-related and government services. The vision for 211 Alberta is to be the primary source of information and gateway to human services for individuals and planners.

SUN BOARD OF DIRECTORS 2021 – 2022

Gordon Voth - President	Wayne Sorenson - Vice President	William Holtz - Treasurer
Secretary - VACANT	Gerald Northam - Director	Bert Reich - Director
Robert Price - Director Stan Poznanski - Director		

SUN STAFF

Linda Osborne - Executive Director 780-920-3058 sunexdir@telus.net
Deborah Wilson – SUN Membership Coordinator 780-999-2313 suncoord@telus.net
Lynn Penner - Office Administration 780-449-1816 unitenow@telus.net

Presidents' Report

The year 2020 was unique and had a significant impact on SUN. It required the board to evaluate how we could continue to communicate effectively during the COVID-19 pandemic. We were mandated to cancel all face-to-face meetings therefore we had to switch to a Zoom meeting protocol. We accomplished this with much practice and a considerable learning curve.

Our largest challenge of 2020 was to organize a Zoom AGM in September. It was a difficult process, but we persevered and were able to hold the legally required meeting. Reports were presented, Motions were passed, and SUN members elected to the Board. All in all, it went very well. The board sends a big thank you to our staff, Linda, Lynn, and Deb for all the hard work they did to make the AGM possible.

With no face-to-face meetings or events, we had to modify our approach in dealing with the government and involving SUN in their decision-making process. We resorted to written communications, e-mails, and phone calls. We also continued to stay in touch with our members by publishing our newsletter, SUNBURST, we sent our e-bulletins with information updates between newsletters. We plan to return to in-person meetings in September 2021, if safe to do so. In the meantime, some chapters are providing guest speakers, via zoom, for all members. We would encourage all our members to join in from home, by your computer or phone.

Our advocacy program continues to be of service to our members by telephone or e-mail. These calls are all responded to and we jointly seek solution for these issues. Unfortunately, we are not able to meet with ministers, but we have communicated to ministers on senior's issues and concerns by letter. On the 2021 budget, SUN sent a letter to Premier Kenney, in February, outlining SUN 's concerns regarding issues that affect seniors that must be addressed in the budget. These issues are:

COVID-19 - The pandemic has affected all Albertans lives. We need funds provided for a timely vaccination program, with no breaks in the supply chain.

The Economy - Without a strong economy, all Albertans, especially fixed income seniors lose ground and become worse off.

Business recovery - A failing business community means that prices rise, and goods are in short supply. Senior independence is threatened.

Long-term care - The significant number of deaths in long-term care is alarming. A complete review of the system is necessary to safeguard seniors.

I am pleased to report that we received a response from Premier Kenney. It was positive and assuring that our concerns would be addressed within the budget. (See page 13)

Also of note, I was invited by CARP-Calgary to participate on a committee to present a petition to Premier Kenney, strongly urging him to appoint an Independent Seniors Advocate. This endeavor is still in process and a meeting with the Premier is being requested for June 2021. I was also pleased to hear that Lori Sigurdson, NDP, senior's critic has tabled a private members bill to establish an Independent Seniors Advocate. It is SUNs experience that the previous seniors advocate was a valuable resource for seniors and SUN's advocacy program.

During these trying times, I would urge our members to stay in touch with family and friends, by phone, Zoom, Skype, and FaceTime. It is important to maintain contacts during this pandemic.

Keep well and help others.

Gordon Voth

WEAAD 2021: Rights Don't Get Old

Since 2006, communities throughout the country and around the world have honored this day to raise the visibility of elder abuse by organizing events to share information and promote resources and services that can help increase seniors' safety and well-being. Elder Abuse networks and organizations are planning multiple WEAAD activities across the country to mobilize community action and engage people in discussions on how to promote dignity and respect of older adults.

The basic human rights of older Canadians are challenged and undercut every day and, tragically, this has never been truer than over the last year during the COVID-19 pandemic. It is estimated that 7 to 10% of older Canadians are victims of elder abuse. 1 in 6 seniors globally.

We cannot allow this to continue.

This WEAAD, CNPEA, EAPO and CanAge are teaming up to create a national conversation around elder abuse prevention and what each of us can do to uphold and protect the rights of seniors in your community.

Throughout the campaign, we will be sharing compelling statistics and useful resources, igniting a national conversation and shining a light on the need to create a coordinated pan-Canadian approach to elder abuse prevention.

Register for a free online event, the June 15th webinar, entitled 'Aging with Rights: Ending Elder Abuse in Canada', is the main event of WEAAD 2021.

It is a not-to-be-missed interactive national event that brings together a panel of experts, political figures, advocates and concerned people like you to engage in an inspiring discussion about how we, as a country, can fight elder abuse and protect the rights of older people.

Make sure you secure your seat quickly, as space is limited.

Visit the website: we will be launching a dedicated website at www.WEAAD.ca. This page will serve as the central hub of our campaign, and will contain everything you need to get informed and get engaged:

Rights Don't Get Old

On June 15, stand up for the human rights of older adults.



WEAAD.CA



#WEAAD2021
#RightsDoNotGetOld



North West Edmonton Chapter A message to our chapter members

We will re-start our in-person NW Edmonton meetings when we can safely gather, and we will let you know when that will happen. I expect there will be a lot of interest in meeting topics related to the fallout from the current health crisis. Both physical health and mental well-being.

In the meantime, we encourage you to join in on the Zoom meetings being hosted by Edmonton NE and Sherwood Park Chapters.

Your support and talents are wanted, please consider volunteering for our Chapter.

Growing up isn't what it used to be, is it?

If you grew up in a generation before there was fast food, you may want to share some of these memories with your children or grandchildren. Just don't blame me if they bust a gut laughing. I shared this with my eight-year-old grandson 'We didn't have fast food when I was growing up,' I informed him. 'All the food was slow.' 'C'mon, seriously? Where did you eat?' 'It was a place called 'home,' I explained. 'Mum cooked every day and when Dad got home from work, we sat down together at the dining room table, and if I didn't like what she put on my plate, I was allowed to sit there until I did like it.'

By this time, the lad was laughing so hard I was afraid he was going to suffer serious internal damage, so I didn't tell him the part about how I had to have permission to leave the table.

But here are some other things I would have told him about my childhood if I figured his system could have handled it:

Some parents NEVER owned their own house, wore jeans, set foot on a golf course, travelled out of the country, or had a credit card. My parents never drove me to school... I had a bicycle that weighed probably 50 pounds, and only had one speed (slow). We didn't have a television in our house until I was 10. It was, of course, black and white, and the station went off the air at 10 PM, after playing the national anthem and epilogue; it came back on the air at about 6 am. And there was usually a locally produced news and farm show on, featuring local people... Pizzas were not delivered to our home, but milk was. All newspapers were delivered by boys and all boys delivered newspapers.

Author unknown

North East Edmonton Chapter**Quarterly Activity Summary**

I am optimistically hopeful that some of the COVID-19 Pandemic restrictions will be eased by the time you read this article. Only time will tell when we are able to get back to our pre-pandemic meetings.

However, in the meantime we have been holding our monthly Zoom virtual meetings since February 2021. For you to stay connected, informed, and able to voice your thoughts on seniors' issues. You can join our Zoom meeting by computer or telephone. Prior to each meeting an email invitation, to join the meeting is sent out to all SUN members that have enlisted in our email program via our website. You may also contact the SUN office by either sending an email or phoning to get the Zoom link information. Please note a Zoom account is **NOT** required to participate in these sessions.

WHATS HAPPENED?

MARCH 11, 2021 Guest speaker Joly Hall, owner of Edmonton 55 described the process of what you need to know to understand to decide if you should move or stay in your home. She helped you gain insight and confidence in making the best decision for you and your circumstances.

APRIL 8, 2021 Through the UNITED WAY we were able to book guest speakers Chad Gunraj (TD Canada Trust) and Adam Lv (CIBC) who spoke to Financial Abuse, Health and Mental Capacity, Warning signs, Counterfeit Bank notes, Advanced Planning Tools, Resources and much more.

May 13, 2021

Guest speaker Dr. Chery Ann Hoffmeyer from the Therapeutic Touch Network of Alberta shared information and experiences with the natural approach to healing. She illustrated several techniques that we could use to experience a sense of peacefulness and relaxation during a time when many things seem so stressful.

WHATS UPCOMING?**JUNE 10, 2021 Essential Oils 101**

Guest speaker Darren Smadis will conduct his Essential Oils 101 presentation which covers pain management, mental clarity, and depression. We encourage and appreciate those of you that can attend this presentation.

NOTE: MEETINGS ARE NOT HELD IN JULY AND AUGUST.

SEPTEMBER 9, 2021

A speaker has not yet been scheduled.

Wayne Sorenson Chairperson, Edmonton North East Chapter


**ADMINISTRATION MODIFICATION TO MEMBERSHIP
RENEWAL DUE DATES**

To simplify administrative labor, renewal months will be slightly changed for some members.

1st Quarter - **JANUARY** (January February & March)

2nd Quarter - **APRIL** (April, May & June)

3rd Quarter - **SEPTEMBER** (July, August & September)

4th Quarter - **NOVEMBER** (October, November & December)

Memberships are considered current until the **END** of the quarter in which they are due for renewal.

Thanks for your understanding. Lynn Penner – Office Admin

CASH RAFFLE – Winners

Volunteer Virtues ...We Celebrate YOU!

April 19, 2021 License #570434

Congratulations to SUN members:

D. Cingel - Red Deer ticket #421

P. Haase - Torrington ticket #408

Thanks to all members for supporting SUN's critical fundraising by purchasing tickets!

Sherwood Park / Strathcona County Chapter (SPSC)

Quarterly Activity Summary

Despite the surge of the third wave of COVID-19 in Alberta our SUN Chapter has been remarkably successful in delivering informative, educational, and safe sessions to many of our members in the region and around the province with an audience between 40 and 50 attendees on the Zoom platform. Kudos go out to our dedicated SUN executive who have helped to call our members and “check in” on them many of whom are not able to participate online because of age or inadequate technology.

February 16, 2021 We heard from Priscilla M Koop, PhD, on “What is Mindfulness- How can it Help to Maintain Mental and Cognitive Well-Being? Dr. Koop told us that mindfulness can help to slow down our minds, help us to focus our thoughts and live more in the present moment. We can use meditation in a non-religious way to develop our mindfulness. Priscilla took us through two different exercises to help us focus our minds on seeing, hearing, or breathing. These exercises are used to develop a growing sense of awareness to the sights and sounds around us. Confidentiality plays an important role in sharing these sensations and impressions with the group. One common element is the ability of the mind to stray or wander from what it is trying to focus on. This is normal and we must simply guide our thoughts back to what it is we are trying to focus on. This helps to develop “attentional performance” and helps to exercise the mind. Writing down or noting these (stray thoughts) can give us insight into thought patterns and that might be causing anxiety and concern. These can be probed later. Mindfulness can lead to decreased anxiety, decreased depression, improved mood, better listening skills and more importantly living in the present moment.

March 16, 2021 China: What should Canada’s Position Be? An enlightening and alarming presentation from our Member of Parliament, Garnet Genus, shadow cabinet minister for foreign affairs, who gave us a brief historical overview of how The People’s Republic of China (PRC) has become one of the superpowers today. China has emerged as an all controlling, world-wide network designed to monitor, control, and subdue its competitors in all aspects of the economy and exercise political power in the interests of PRC. Alarm bells have been going off with accusations of human rights violations related to the genocide of Uighurs minority group in China, the occupation of Tibet, the violations of treaties in Hong Kong and closer to home the imprisonment of the two Michaels and the arrest of the Huawei executive, Meng Wanzhou. To counter-act the infiltration of the PRC, Canada needs to develop a growing awareness and understanding of China’s presence in Canada, develop policies regarding our interactions with China, protect national security interests, be aware of the potential of intellectual property theft and build partnerships with other countries through IPAK a group of world legislators who seek to share information and concerns.

April 28, 2021 We attended via Zoom the SUN AGM with guest motivational speaker Patricia Morgan.

May 18, 2021 We listened to Ellen Thompson-Jennings who introduced us to Family History-It’s more than Names and Dates. Ms. Thompson-Jennings started bringing to life genealogy and history by showing us how she researched her own family tree and talked about the wonderful people, places and stories that brought her to where she is today. She also gives us a focus point to begin our own study. As she outlines in her excellent hand-out:

To start off it is a good idea to establish your research goals. What is it you are trying to achieve? Your goal can be made up of a large goal and then smaller goals as you work on your tree. It is best to start with yourself and work backward in time. It is easy to think that you should start with your parents but in this case “you’re the star”. There are many sites that offer forms to fill out to capture the information. (She lists many of these on her hand-out that are available on the SUN website). Set aside several pages in a notebook or in a word document to add information as you recall it.

Ms. Thompson-Jennings emphasizes one of the most common complaints by people doing genealogy is that they do not cite their sources. The idea is that this is important for the future when other people want to locate the “Who, What, Where and When” of the people in question. Other important techniques for gathering information are journaling, creating timelines and the use of QR codes. She also provides many sources and internet sites where you can record your ancestry in family trees and indicates which ones are free and which ones you must pay for. There are three main kinds of DNA testing: 1. Y DNA which traces the paternal side 2. mtDNA which traces the mother’s side 3. Autosomal DNA testing which relates more to ancestry and ethnicity. One of her important tips is: Video and auditory recordings or files are much more interesting than looking at family trees and should be used and incorporated whenever possible. Phones and computers provide excellent and handy tools for doing this.

June 15, 2021 Topic: Saving Manno – “An Alberta man's quest to rescue a chimpanzee from Iraq”

Speaker: Spencer Sekyer, Author - Bursting with compassion, inspiration, and courage, Saving Manno is a testament to the fact that every one of us has the power to change lives and make the world a better place.

September 21, 2021 Strathcona County Mayorality Forum - (tentative)

Report respectfully submitted by:

Denis Beaudry Chairperson, SPSC Chapter

Join us! We welcome your wisdom, experience, and enthusiasm!



South Edmonton Chapter**A message to our chapter members**

Fourteen months have passed since our last South Chapter presentation, but we hope that we might be able to restart in September 2021. Much depends on more vaccinations and the opening up of Whitemud Public Library where we hold our meetings.

Sadly, another of our executive members, Narain Khemchandani, passed away recently. We will miss his thoughtful ideas, his work in preparation for our meetings, his friendly greetings, and many other contributions.

Four of our executive members phoned our entire chapter membership, including those who were past due, about activities that were still being held at our virtual monthly meetings. Also, we reminded them about the renewal of memberships. This is important since the main source of funds at the present is from your memberships. In the past, the largest source of funds for SUN came from a casino every eighteen months. However, due to Covid-19, a casino for SUN and many other societies, has been postponed. As you are likely aware, SUN does not receive any government funding.

We also informed our members about the April AGM and how to join up through Zoom or by phone. Our guest speaker, Patricia Morgan, with a MA in Clinical Psychology, is a therapeutic counsellor, author, speaker, and mentor who works with many organizations and individuals on resilience. Her remarkable presentation was on loneliness. Ms. Morgan said we must realize that loneliness involves not just oneself but others. To solve our loneliness concerns we must connect with others facing the same problems as well as organizations that can provide social support. SUN is an example of this, but other people can be contacted by phone, e-mail, Zoom or even old-fashioned letter writing. She mentioned the importance of distinguishing between socializing and receiving attention. Socializing is connecting to others and engaging in conversation or other means of contact. Receiving attention is receiving recognition, which can be by a simple "hello" or just sitting down with another to watch TV.

People also react to loneliness in different ways. As Ms. Morgan suggested, some people who are more introverted are energized by being alone. I am an example of this since I have doing a lot of writing that has kept me busy, and then I can let others read what I have done. Discussion follows and that's where the socialization begins. In fact, right now as I write this report, I have been working on two other articles today, forcing my ideas to line up in queue to be dealt with. I also have been working on an autobiography which brings up memories of my past, including events, people, and numerous experiences.

As a final comment, we would appreciate if anyone would like to volunteer to join our illustrious and wonderful executive. It will take only a few hours a month, and we always have fun planning for our next meeting. Consider contacting one of us if you are interested. If things work out, we will try to have a meeting in September 2021.

Enjoy the coming warmer days and stay safe!

Cynthia Lazarenko and Robert Price Co-chair Edmonton South Chapter
Contact Bob at 780-250-7164 and e-mail: rogp@shaw.ca
Cynthia Lazarenko at 780-9720 or e-mail: lazarcj@shaw.ca

**Remembering a special volunteer**

South Edmonton Chapter, on behalf of the SUN Provincial Board and staff. Extends its sympathies to the family of Narain Khemchandani, Narain was an integral part of the South Edmonton Chapter Executive team. Having volunteered for several years.

Narain Khemchandani died peacefully April 13th in Edmonton, Alberta at the age of 81. He will be lovingly remembered by his devoted wife of 56 years, Suneeta, his daughter Reeta (Iqbal) and son Rajesh (Madhu), and grandchildren. Narain loved to travel, he loved to talk, and express his views on anything. He was blunt and funny, and he loved to walk with Suneeta in the malls and in the parks. He also enjoyed a good meal and conversation with his friends and family. We will all miss him tremendously.

Annual General Meeting Review April 28, 2021

The Board of Directors held a Zoom Annual General Meeting on April 28, 2021. We had sufficient members respond to declare a quorum was in attendance. A quorum consists of a majority of the Board of Directors and 50 voting members in attendance. I am pleased to report that the entire board was in attendance.

The AGM was called to order at 10:02 am. A Presidents report, Executive Directors report and a Financial report were presented. Motions were presented by members of the board. These motions seconded by members in attendance, discussed and voted on. All motions passed.

Nominations were held for the following vacant board positions:

President-Gordon Voth, Directors at Large-Robert Price, Bert Reich. All nominees were elected by acclamation. Mr. Barrie Pratt, CPA was appointed as auditor for the fiscal year of 2021.

Following the meeting, we moved to our speakers' series. We had the pleasure of hearing from Patricia Morgan, a resiliency, happiness, and senior's expert. She provided an enlightening presentation on:

Understanding Loneliness: What to do for Yourself and Others.

It was enjoyed by all.

Executive Director Report

Over the past months since our last AGM, there have been many ups and downs. Every time we showed progress, the COVID-19 numbers went up and again more restrictions. However, SUN and its members continue to weather the storm.

Recently, I have had the opportunity to speak with members across the province by phone and will continue to do so in the coming weeks. When speaking with the member, I ask questions like "how are you doing?" "Do you have someone to help with groceries and appointments?" The common answer from the member was, they were doing what they could to stay safe and that they had some support either through family, friends, and neighbours.

Everyone I talked to had already had their first vaccine and many their second. To me that just showed what great members SUN has and we appreciate their support. I would also like to acknowledge the phoning committees for our chapters, who have made calls to members to keep in touch as we have not been able to meet in person.

I have continued to attend Zoom meetings with other organizations. For example, Edmonton Senior Coordinating Council (which is a network of groups who support seniors), Public Interest Alberta Senior Task Force and the Alberta Pharmacare Working Group. I attend these meetings to gain information of what is being put into place to support seniors across this province and to pass on to our members.

I look forward to the day when we can all meet again in person.

Respectfully submitted,

Linda Osborne sunexdir@telus.net cell: 780-920-3058

Our next Cash Raffle is: "Have a Healthy Heart"

Draw Date September 29, 2021

License #574580

See page 15 for ticket order form or

purchase online: www.seniorsunitednow.com

Tickets \$5.00 each 5 Tickets \$10.00 20 tickets \$20.00

Please consider supporting SUN's critical fundraising.



What to do about Isolation and Loneliness

May 2021, Patricia Morgan, MA CCC

In the February 2021 issue of Sunburst, there was a short and helpful article called **Social Isolation**. It acknowledged that seniors, particularly those of older generations, are vulnerable to isolation and its consequent state of loneliness. Loneliness can lead to physical and mental health issues. The article includes tips on how to approach those you imagine are experiencing loneliness with phone calls, letters, and encouragement.

Here I suggest some ways to monitor and attend to your own loneliness so that, when you approach another, you do so from a sense of overflow.

The loneliness researcher, John T. Cacioppo wrote, "We can all slip in and out of loneliness. Feeling lonely at any particular moment simply means that you are human. . . Loneliness becomes an issue of serious concern only when it settles in long enough to create a persistent, self-reinforcing loop of negative thoughts, sensations, and behaviors." So, where do we begin to minimize loneliness?

Step One: Become Aware of the Signals

Loneliness itself signals that you do not have the amount of connection that you desire.

- Notice unexplained feelings such as sadness, emptiness, or disconnect. You might burst into tears for no identified reason. You might feel more irritable, angry, or anxious.
- Catch your behaviors, particularly increased consumption of alcohol, food or other substances that numb feelings. Also watch for disrupted sleep, and lack of judgement plus impulsiveness.

Step Two: Use the Antidote of Connection

1. Assess your own level of need for social interaction. There is no concern if you are comfortable with your allotted alone time.
2. Get comfortable in your own skin. Connect with yourself and accept that a certain degree of loneliness is inevitable.
3. Decide if you need to do something different, including reaching out.
4. Engage in an activity that gives you a sense of purpose. For example, you might want to increase your involvement in SUN.
5. Embrace technology to the degree you can. During the pandemic, getting on a Zoom call can compensate for the need to minimize physical contact.
6. Reach out to an old friend or family member you have not spoken to for years. Check out who they have become since you last spent time together.
7. In Canada find **The Loneliness Project** on Facebook and/or Instagram.
8. Develop an optimistic perspective about relationships. People who are lonely tend to expect rejection. You are best to focus on positive interactions.
9. Use the community social supports in place and waiting for you. We want to remove the stigma of feeling lonely. Dial and say, "I feel lonely."
10. If you are stuck in a state of loneliness, please consider reaching out to a helping professional.



Especially during these challenging times, may you feel supported, connected, and resilient!

With a Masters Degree in Clinical Psychology, **Patricia Morgan** is an author, speaker, and therapist. Her counselling services are covered by several Canadian Health Insurance programs. You can learn more about her work at <https://www.solutionsforresilience.com>

Cardiovascular disease continues to be the leading cause of death and disability in the world today.

The term 'cardiovascular disease' (CVD) refers to any disease of the heart, vascular disease of the brain, or disease of the blood vessel. More people die from CVDs worldwide than from any other cause: over 17.9 million every year, according to the World Health Organization.

Did you know that your heart is the size of your fist and the strongest muscle in your body? It started beating about three weeks after you were conceived. If you live to be 70, it will have beaten two and a half billion times. However, although impressive and strong, your heart can also become vulnerable from habitual risk factors like smoking, eating an unhealthy diet or putting it under stress. Controlling these key risk factors and monitoring your blood pressure regularly may reduce an individual's risk of CVD.

The system can also be weakened from a pre-existing heart condition and other physiological factors, including hypertension or high blood cholesterol. When your heart's functions become compromised, this is known as cardiovascular disease, a broad term that covers any disorder to the system that has the heart at its centre.

You will not necessarily develop cardiovascular disease if you have a risk factor. But the more risk factors you have, the greater the likelihood that you will, unless you take action to modify your risk factors and work to prevent them compromising your heart health.

Modifiable risk factors include:

Physical inactivity, Unhealthy diet, Raised blood pressure, Tobacco use, Cholesterol, Obesity and being overweight

Non-modifiable risk factors include:

Family history, Diabetes, Age: simply getting old is a risk factor for cardiovascular disease; risk of stroke doubles every decade after age 55. Gender: your gender is significant: as a man you are at greater risk of heart disease than a pre-menopausal woman. But once past the menopause, a woman's risk is similar to a man's. Risk of stroke is similar for men and women. Ethnicity: your ethnic origin plays a role. People with African or Asian ancestry are at higher risks of developing cardiovascular disease than other racial groups. Socioeconomic status: being poor, no matter where in the globe, increases your risk of heart disease and stroke. A chronically stressful life, social isolation, anxiety, and depression also increase the risk.

<https://www.world-heart-federation.org>



World Heart Day 2021

World Heart Day 2021 Every year September 29th is celebrated as World Heart Day. Heart diseases come under the category of non-communicable disorders: they do not transmit from one person to another. Among the many causes of death of the human population, heart ailments stand in the number one position.



**WORLD
HEART
DAY** 29 SEP



COVID 19 exposes Urgent need for National Pharmacare Program

Despite a long history of calls for national pharmacare in Canada, beginning with the introduction of our universal health care system, we still do not have it. Why not? Pharmacare has been called the unfinished business of Medicare, leaving Canada as the only country that has a public health care system which does not cover prescription drugs outside of hospital. During this time, we have seen never-ending studies and parliamentary budgetary reports, which support and recommend the implementation of this much needed plan. The latest being the final report from Dr. Eric Hoskins and the Advisory Council on the Implementation of National Pharmacare – A Prescription for Canada: Achieving Pharmacare for All – released in June 2019, it serves as a road map for how to implement it. The Report estimates an annual saving of five billion dollars in drug costs. The only thing lacking over the course of the last 53 years has been the political will to improve the lives of Canadians. It begs the question – why have governments chosen to ignore the will and needs of Canadians?

This past year, we have often heard that “we are all in this together”, and yet we are not all in the same position to deal with this health emergency. Vulnerable populations bore the brunt of this pandemic, with seniors suffering the most tragic outcomes. For example, Canada leads the way among OECD countries in the percentage of COVID-19 deaths in Long Term Care facilities (81% compared to the average of 42%). Why is this concerning?

As people live longer, they often develop complex health problems. The Canadian Institute for Health Information, in its 2016 report titled *Drug Use Among Seniors*, reports that 25 percent of all seniors are prescribed 10 or more drugs, and 65 percent of this group are prescribed five or more drugs.

Living on fixed or limited incomes, seniors face challenges in paying for these medications, as total costs add up, especially when some of their prescriptions are among a growing number of new patented drugs – like in the case of biologics in the treatment of diabetes. 48% of all diabetics are seniors. The Canadian Institute for Health Information reports that in 2019, three diabetes drug classes contributed almost 26% of spending growth.

Canada now faces a health and an economic crisis. The uptake in public drug plans often mirrors the unemployment rate. In Alberta, we have 23 public drug plans (AISH, Alberta Blue Cross for Seniors, etc.). Millions of Canadians have lost employment, and along with that, the coverage of drug benefits previously provided through their employer-insured benefit plans. In January 2021 alone, 213,000 jobs were lost in Canada as reported by the CBC on February 5, 2021, and Alberta’s unemployment rate at 9.9% remains higher than the national average of 8.2%. Furthermore, if our provincial government goes ahead with the Ernst & Young recommendations, seniors can expect to see an out of pocket increase for prescription medications in Long Term Care facilities, where until now they have been covered.

Upstream savings in our health care system through pharmacare would help us regain our financial foothold, and move forward in our economic recovery. According to a World Health Organization report, medication non-adherence accounts for 5% of Canadian hospital admissions, and 5% of physician visits, resulting in an additional \$4 billion in health care costs that could be saved annually as a result of pharmacare.

With a federal election looming, and the overwhelming support of Canadians (over 80%) and hundreds of organizations in the country for a national pharmacare program, coupled with provincial governments consistently begging for more federal transfer funds, it has become more imperative than ever that we follow through with the implementation of a national pharmacare program. It will, most importantly, save the lives of Canadians, but it will also help to deal with the upcoming economic reckoning.

As we move toward a federal election, the question to be asked of all federal candidates is “How can we NOT afford to implement a single payer universal pharmacare plan in Canada?”

SO YOU WANT TO RENOVATE. . .

My sister in Calgary was planning a renovation to her kitchen and main bathroom. She had been talking about it for some time and had many ideas that she wanted to incorporate into the project. She asked me for advice many times during her planning - and during the actual renovations. By the time she began the project in late January 2021 her project had expanded to include a new back entry way to accommodate a new pantry, a full renovation of the kitchen, living room, dining room, upper and lower hallways and two bathrooms. In the early stages of the renovation, it expanded again to include a back deck, a full re-landscaping for the backyard and front yard and new walkways. She is so pleased it has expanded to a phase 2 for the bedrooms and family room. That will begin in January 2022.

I will share with you some of the process that I had her go through to have a successful renovation. Success does not mean no problems, delays, or changes but it does mean you get what you want for the price you want to pay in a time frame that is acceptable. She was able to move back into her renovated place in April – Two and half months after she began. She is so happy with her “new place”, wishing she had done it years earlier.

To make this even more exciting I began the same process to help a friend renovate their kitchen and exterior front appeal. After much time in planning, designing, costing, and considering a nagging desire to live in the country the process got them really thinking of what they wanted. . . they decide to sell rather than renovate and they purchased a new (to them) house away from the city - they found their dream place!

Going after your dream has both exciting times and painful thoughts of why did we ever decide to do this? But, with good planning and a reputable contractor your too can be successful!

1. Planning - I cannot stress enough the need for preplanning. Why do you want to do this project? What are you wanting to accomplish and what will the finished project do for you and your lifestyle.

2. Impact on your life during the renovations - Whether you chose to stay in your home or temporarily move, your life will be greatly impacted and needs to be part of your plan and thoroughly discussed with those close to you and your contractor.

3. Budgeting - Early in the planning the budget should be discussed, and the scope of the project modified if necessary, to the available resources that you want to commit to the project. Be realistic. And, set aside a reasonable contingency for unknowns.

4. Seek help early on - There are a variety of organizations or businesses that can be of great help to you as you plan the scope and design of your project. One such organization in Calgary and Edmonton is Renovation Find where you can explore and connect with local certified contractors or you start with one of the Home and Garden Shows held around Alberta where a large variety of businesses and contractors are more than happy to talk to you about your ideas and give you advice. Also, talk to your friends or neighbours who have done similar projects and see what wisdom they will share with you about their project and who they used and were they happy with their process. Help is not a luxury it is essential!

5. Outline the Details - After you have decided on what you want, what you can afford, and the general timeline for your project put your plan to paper; it is good advice to get professional help from a design firm at this stage in developing a comprehensive plan.

6. Shop for a contractor and unique items you want in your renovation - Select a short list of contractors, interview them, check references, and see if they can meet your timelines and be agreeable to your level desired involvement. Select a contractor Agree to and sign a contract specifying work to be done, who gets permits, timelines, payment schedule, how changes will be handled and how pricing will be adjusted and how disputes will be resolved.

March 14, 2021
Mr. Gordon Voth President
Seniors United Now

Thank you for your February 22, 2021, letter regarding the recent budget and support for seniors. Without a doubt, the COVID-19 pandemic and global recession have created a situation unlike anything we have seen before, and I welcome hearing your thoughts on a number of important issues.

Alberta seniors built this province, and we are standing by them every step of the way- through the pandemic and beyond. Budget 2021 maintains benefits for those most in need, ensuring vulnerable seniors can count on a stable source of income. Over the next year, we will provide \$464 million in financial assistance programs.

At the same time, we are assessing the impacts of the pandemic on older adults who have been left unemployed, incurred increased costs, and who may have drawn on retirement savings earlier than planned. In light of this, we will not proceed with the Alberta Seniors Benefit program changes for new applicants that were announced in Budget 2020.

We have also started work on a strategic plan to ensure seniors and other vulnerable Albertans have access to safe, stable, and affordable housing. Our plan will align with the recommendations made by the Affordable Housing Review Panel. I appreciate your comments about long-term care. As you have likely heard, Budget 2021 includes an historic investment in health care. As part of this, almost \$900 million will be added to the base Health budget to reduce surgical wait times, increase continuing care, and home-care capacity. In addition to an investment of more than \$3.5 billion in continuing care, the budget earmarks over \$500 million in capital spending to create more continuing care spaces. This funding will help upgrade existing spaces while also creating new ones. As we carry out these plans, we will continue to work with our community, non-profit, and independent providers.

With respect to Alberta's vaccine program, we are moving quickly to ensure that all of the doses we receive are available to those who are eligible. On February 19, Alberta Health Services began offering the vaccine directly to all residents in retirement centres, lodges, and supportive living and other congregate living facilities with residents who are aged 75 or older. On February 24, we expanded our program to include any Albertans who were born in 1946 or earlier. On March 4, we announced a further expansion of our rollout plan to all Albertans aged 75 and older, and as of this week, all seniors became eligible to obtain the vaccine.

Finally, I appreciate your comments about business recovery. Our government is working hard to get the economy back on track, for the benefit of all Albertans. Our response to the COVID-19 pandemic has been the priority for government activities; however, we continue to look at ways we can build on Alberta's strengths to attract investment and position our province for prosperity.

Alberta's Recovery Plan focuses on three pillars: creating jobs, building infrastructure, and diversifying our economy. The plan takes bold action with the largest infrastructure build in Alberta's history. Over the next three years, we will invest almost \$21 billion in construction projects to support approximately 90,000 jobs. This plan also includes the many relief programs that we have put into place to support Albertans and job creators through the pandemic.

Thank you again for writing, and for your advocacy. Alberta's government is committed to protecting both lives and livelihoods, and I assure you we will continue to provide outstanding support for seniors in the years ahead.

Best wishes for good health.
Yours sincerely,


Hon. Jason Kenney PC
Premier of Alberta



Message from the Honourable Josephine Pon Minister of Seniors and Housing

It is my pleasure to welcome nominations for the 2021 Minister's Seniors Service Awards. For more than two decades, these awards have honoured remarkable Albertans who work tirelessly to serve and support our province's seniors.

Last year, as Albertans faced a global health crisis, the Minister's Seniors Service Awards focused on the individuals, businesses, and nonprofit organizations who stepped up to help seniors throughout the COVID-19 pandemic.

I am pleased to accept nominations for individuals, businesses, and nonprofit organizations who support seniors through their extraordinary volunteerism, philanthropy, innovation, or outstanding service.

This year, I am introducing the Special Service Award to highlight an area of seniors service that is of particular importance in any given year, the Alberta Spirit. The award will be presented to an individual, business, or nonprofit organization that has brought joy to isolated seniors.

I am also pleased to bring back the Alice Modin Award to honour a senior individual or couple for their exceptional commitment to their community and our province through long-term volunteer efforts. More than 30 years ago, Alice Modin campaigned for a seniors' day in Strathcona County, paving the way for the province-wide Seniors' Week we celebrate to this day.

It is critical for seniors to have the supports and services they need to live healthy, happy lives in the community of their choice. From sharing messages of hope with isolated seniors, to making our communities more accessible, countless individuals, businesses, and nonprofit organizations are supporting seniors day in and day out.

We all know someone who is deserving of an award. They are the doers, the caregivers, the dreamers. They are in your community, your workplace, and your family. Between now and June 30, 2021, I encourage you to take a moment to consider their contributions – big or small – and nominate them for a Minister's Seniors Service Award.

I know Albertans are committed to supporting seniors and to showing appreciation for those who go above and beyond. Together, we will honour this important work.

Josephine Pon
Minister of Seniors and Housing
MLA, Calgary-Beddington



St. Albert & Calgary Chapters

Currently there are no leadership volunteers for a chapter steering committee. These chapters will be in hiatus until volunteers are recruited. For further information please contact:

SUN Executive Director Linda Osborne
Cell: 780-920-3058 Email: sunexdir@telus.net



Have a Healthy Heart...keep the beat!

Name(s): _____

Address: _____

Phone # _____ For Office USE: _____

Email _____
(please print)

Individual Tickets: _____ Tickets \$5.00 each \$ _____ (50 available)

5 tickets \$10.00 _____ Sets \$10.00 each \$ _____ (50 sets available)

20 tickets \$20.00 _____ Sets \$20.00 each \$ _____ (50 sets available)

Draw Date September 29, 2021**License #574580****Please make your cheque
payable to SUN****WORLD
HEART
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1) Raffle tickets must not be sold to a person under the age of 18 years.

2) The purchase price of each ticket shall be:
\$5.00 each OR 5 tickets \$10.00 OR 20 tickets \$20.00

3) To be eligible for draws, the ticket order and purchase amount must be received in SUN office by 10:00am, September 29, 2021

4) The prize payout shall be as follows:

1st prize 30% of the gross ticket sale revenue**2nd prize 20% of the gross ticket sale revenue**

5) The draw(s) shall be made at the SUN office: #37 2016 Sherwood Drive, Sherwood Park, AB T8A3X3 prior to 3pm, September 29, 2021

6) The winning ticket buyers shall be notified by telephone; their names will be publicized in the next newsletter & on the SUN website. The winning ticket buyers will be awarded the prize via cheque drawn on SUN.

7) In the event of any concern or dispute regarding this raffle, please contact Lynn Penner at the SUN administration office. 780-449-1816

8) Raffle tickets are official when payment is received & numbers issued by the sun raffle chairman.

9) Your Ticket numbers are available by contacting the SUN office

SUN MEMBERSHIP Renewal / Donation April – Sept 2021Individual: ☐ \$25 per year ☐ \$50 2 years Lifetime: ☐ \$200Joint: ☐ \$40 per year ☐ \$80 2 years Lifetime: ☐ \$300**Donation in addition to membership dues**☐ \$5 ☐ \$10 ☐ \$15 ☐ \$20 ☐ \$25 ☐ other \$ _____Renewal \$ _____ Donation \$ _____ Raffle \$ _____ **Please make cheque payable to Seniors United Now**Signed Cheque(s) enclosed Chq# _____ Total \$ _____ **Your stamp on our return envelope helps us reduce postage costs**

Membership # _____ (see Back Page)

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☐ YES - replace my membership card☐ YES - replace my membership card**(Please attach a stamped self-addressed stamped envelope if you are requesting a replacement card)**

Name: _____

Name: _____

Year of Birth: _____ (used for SUN demographics only)

Year of Birth: _____ (used for SUN demographics only)

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E-Mail Communication

SUN Administrator
newsletter@seniorsunitednow.com

We thank all those members that have subscribed to our electronic communications that are sent out via our Website program. If you have not yet subscribed, you may do this by visiting our website and clicking JOIN OUR EMAIL LIST.

What communications are sent out?

Messages, information, and updates to all our members including the invitations to participate in the zoom virtual meetings. As these are preprogrammed messages sent in bulk, some members have had situations where their computer virus security program is automatically "unsubscribing" from our email communications. We suggest that this may be alleviated by adding the newsletter SUN administrator address newsletter@seniorsunitednow.com into your personal contacts.

Return Undeliverable Canadian Addresses to:

Unit #37 15 - 2016 Sherwood Drive,
Sherwood Park, Alberta, T8A 3X3

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Thank-you for being a
SUN member, your
membership is: